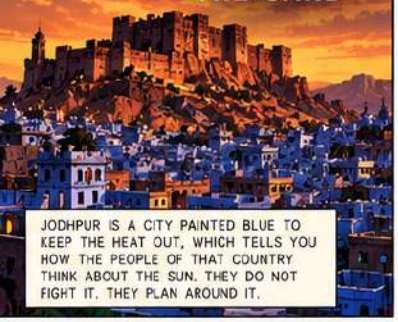
BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 1

THE SAND

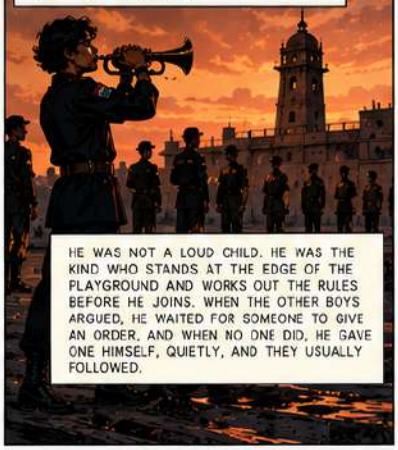


JODHPUR IS A CITY PAINTED BLUE TO KEEP THE HEAT OUT, WHICH TELLS YOU HOW THE PEOPLE OF THAT COUNTRY THINK ABOUT THE SUN. THEY DO NOT FIGHT IT. THEY PLAN AROUND IT.

ADITYA SHEKHAWAT WAS BORN IN A CANTONMENT QUARTER ON THE EDGE OF THE CITY. THE ONLY SON OF SUBEDAR MAJOR BHANWAR SINGH SHEKHAWAT OF THE RAJPUTANA RIFLES AND HIS WIFE KAMLA, A STAFF NURSE AT THE GOVERNMENT HOSPITAL WHO WORKED NIGHTS AND SLEPT THROUGH THE DAY BEHIND A CURTAIN HER SON LEARNED NEVER TO TOUCH.

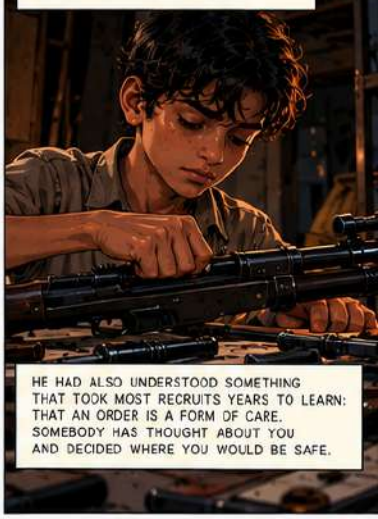


HIS CHILDHOOD RAN ON BUGLE CALLS. REVEILLE AT FIVE. LIGHTS OUT AT NINE. HIS FATHER BELIEVED A HOUSE WAS A SMALL UNIT, AND A UNIT NEEDED A ROUTINE, AND THE BOY TOOK TO IT THE WAY OTHER BOYS TOOK TO CRICKET.



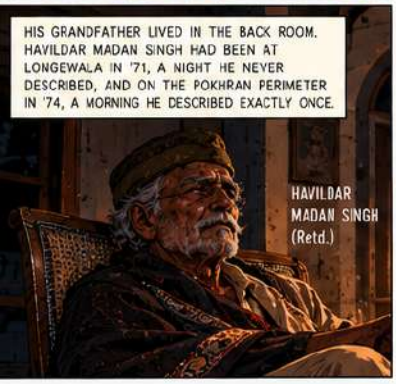
HE WAS NOT A LOUD CHILD. HE WAS THE KIND WHO STANDS AT THE EDGE OF THE PLAYGROUND AND WORKS OUT THE RULES BEFORE HE JOINS. WHEN THE OTHER BOYS ARGUED, HE WAITED FOR SOMEONE TO GIVE AN ORDER, AND WHEN NO ONE DID, HE GAVE ONE HIMSELF, QUIETLY, AND THEY USUALLY FOLLOWED.

BY TWELVE HE COULD STRIP HIS FATHER'S OLD SERVICE RIFLE BLINDFOLDED.



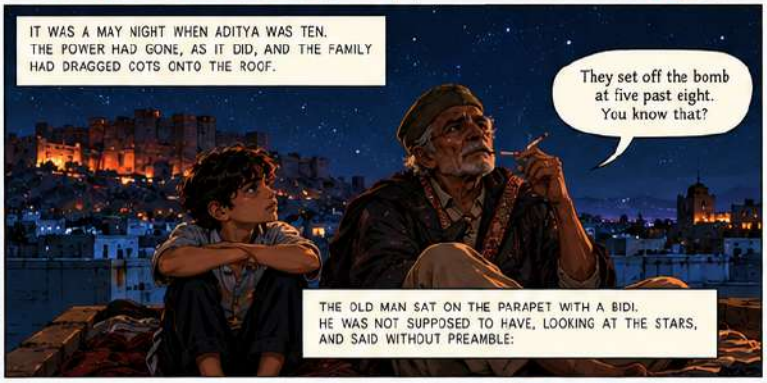
HE HAD ALSO UNDERSTOOD SOMETHING THAT TOOK MOST RECRUITS YEARS TO LEARN: THAT AN ORDER IS A FORM OF CARE. SOMEBODY HAS THOUGHT ABOUT YOU AND DECIDED WHERE YOU WOULD BE SAFE.

HIS GRANDFATHER LIVED IN THE BACK ROOM. HAVILDAR MADAN SINGH HAD BEEN AT LONGEWALA IN '71, A NIGHT HE NEVER DESCRIBED, AND ON THE POKHRAN PERIMETER IN '74, A MORNING HE DESCRIBED EXACTLY ONCE.



HAVILDAR MADAN SINGH (Retd.)

IT WAS A MAY NIGHT WHEN ADITYA WAS TEN. THE POWER HAD GONE, AS IT DID, AND THE FAMILY HAD DRAGGED COTS ONTO THE ROOF.



THE OLD MAN SAT ON THE PARAPET WITH A BIDI. HE WAS NOT SUPPOSED TO HAVE, LOOKING AT THE STARS, AND SAID WITHOUT PREAMBLE:



He tapped ash into the dark.

"THE FIRE WENT DOWN, INTO THE GROUND. THAT WAS WHAT THEY WANTED. BUT WHEN IT WAS OVER, THE SAND WAS BURNING.

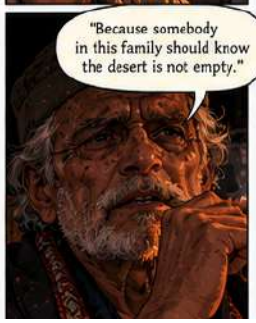
"NOT SMOKE. NOT FLAME. A RING OF WHITE-GOLD LIGHT ON BARE GROUND, WITH NOTHING IN IT TO BURN.

"NINE MINUTES BY MY WATCH. THEN MEN IN SUITS CAME AND HAD US SIGN A PAPER SAYING WE'D SEEN NOTHING."





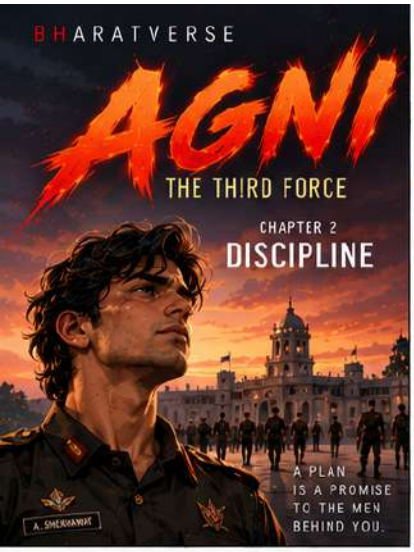


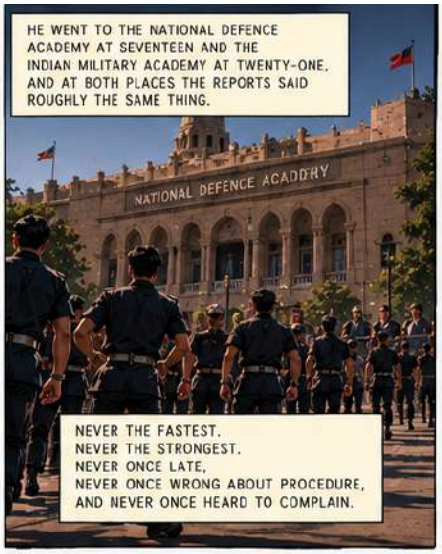


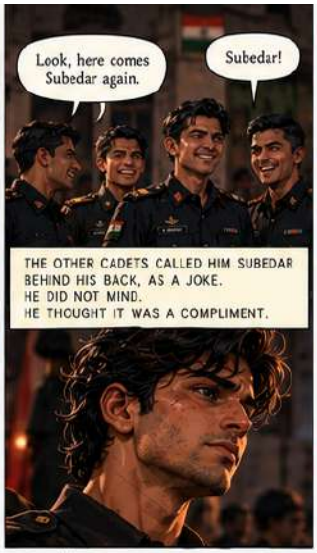
ADITYA THOUGHT IT WAS A SOLDIER'S TALL TALE. HE LOVED IT ANYWAY.

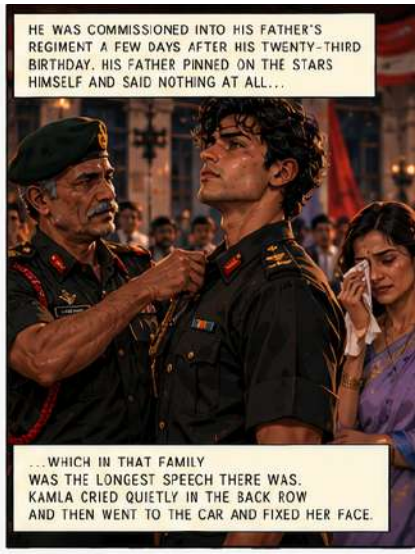


HE KEPT IT THE WAY HE KEPT EVERYTHING HIS GRANDFATHER GAVE HIM: FOLDED SMALL, IN A PLACE WHERE IT WOULD STAY.

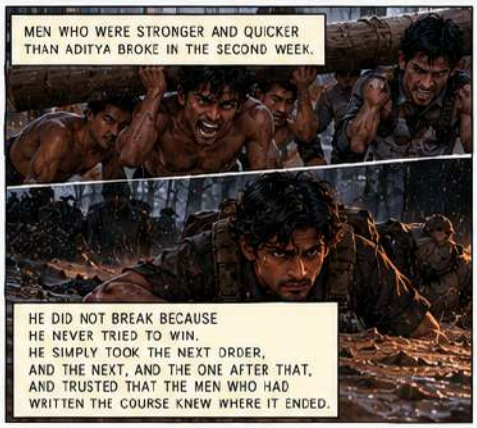

BHARATVERSE
AGNI
THE THIRD FORCE
CHAPTER 2
DISCIPLINE
A PLAN IS A PROMISE TO THE MEN BEHIND YOU.


HE WENT TO THE NATIONAL DEFENCE ACADEMY AT SEVENTEEN AND THE INDIAN MILITARY ACADEMY AT TWENTY-ONE. AND AT BOTH PLACES THE REPORTS SAID ROUGHLY THE SAME THING.
NATIONAL DEFENCE ACADEMY
NEVER THE FASTEST.
NEVER THE STRONGEST.
NEVER ONCE LATE,
NEVER ONCE WRONG ABOUT PROCEDURE,
AND NEVER ONCE HEARD TO COMPLAIN.

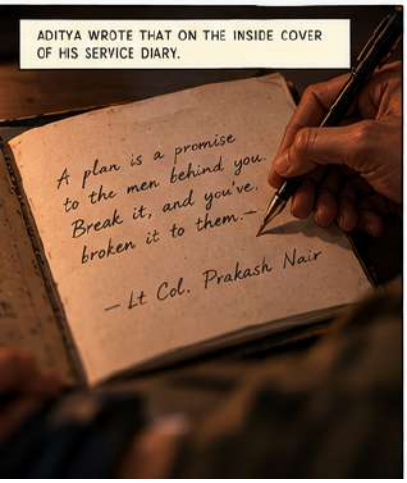

Look, here comes Subedar again.
Subedar!
THE OTHER CADETS CALLED HIM SUBEDAR BEHIND HIS BACK, AS A JOKE.
HE DID NOT MIND.
HE THOUGHT IT WAS A COMPLIMENT.


HE WAS COMMISSIONED INTO HIS FATHER'S REGIMENT A FEW DAYS AFTER HIS TWENTY-THIRD BIRTHDAY. HIS FATHER PINNED ON THE STARS HIMSELF AND SAID NOTHING AT ALL...
...WHICH IN THAT FAMILY WAS THE LONGEST SPEECH THERE WAS. KAMLA CRIED QUIETLY IN THE BACK ROW AND THEN WENT TO THE CAR AND FIXED HER FACE.

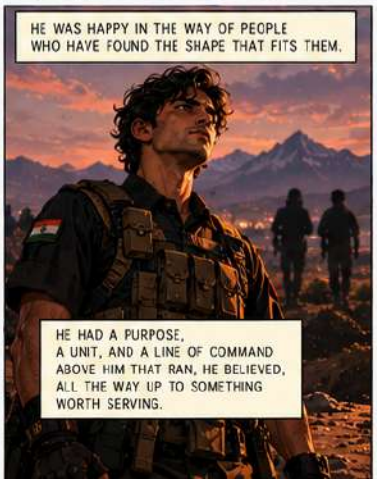

AT TWENTY-FIVE HE VOLUNTEERED FOR THE SPECIAL FORCES PROBATION.
THE SELECTION WAS NINETY DAYS OF DESIGNED MISERY: SLEEP REMOVED, FOOD REMOVED, CERTAINTY REMOVED, A THING THE INSTRUCTORS CALLED THE **STRIP-DOWN.**

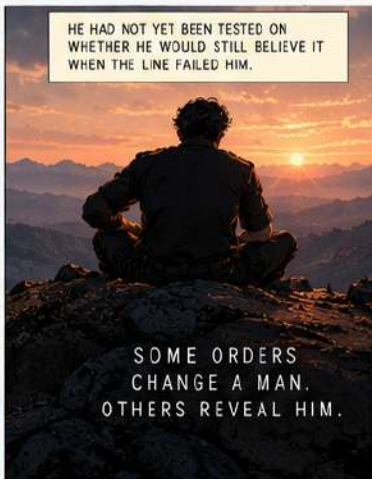

MEN WHO WERE STRONGER AND QUICKER THAN ADITYA BROKE IN THE SECOND WEEK.
HE DID NOT BREAK BECAUSE
HE NEVER TRIED TO WIN.
HE SIMPLY TOOK THE NEXT ORDER,
AND THE NEXT, AND THE ONE AFTER THAT,
AND TRUSTED THAT THE MEN WHO HAD WRITTEN THE COURSE KNEW WHERE IT ENDED.


HIS COMMANDING OFFICER, LIEUTENANT COLONEL PRAKASH NAIR, NOTICED. NAIR WAS A LEAN, TIRED MAN WITH A MALAYALI ACCENT AND THE HABIT OF SPEAKING TO RECRUITS AS IF THEY WERE ADULTS.
You know why I'm passing you?
Not because you're the best. Because you're the one I'd trust to follow a bad plan carefully and a good plan perfectly.
A plan is a promise to the men behind you. Break it, and you've broken it to them.


ADITYA WROTE THAT ON THE INSIDE COVER OF HIS SERVICE DIARY.
A plan is a promise to the men behind you. Break it, and you've broken it to them.—
—Lt Col. Prakash Nair


HE SENT HIS FATHER A POSTCARD FROM EVERY POSTING, FIVE LINES, NOTHING ABOUT THE WORK. HIS FATHER KEPT THEM IN A TIN.
LEH
All well. Weather tough. Good men. Learning. Your son, Aditya.
Received 12 Oct 2023
ON THE BACK OF EACH, IN PENCIL, IN THE CAREFUL HAND OF A MAN WHO HAD LEARNED TO WRITE LATE, HE NOTED THE DATE RECEIVED.
—Bhanwar Singh Shekhawat


HE WAS HAPPY IN THE WAY OF PEOPLE WHO HAVE FOUND THE SHAPE THAT FITS THEM.
HE HAD A PURPOSE,
A UNIT, AND A LINE OF COMMAND ABOVE HIM THAT RAN, HE BELIEVED, ALL THE WAY UP TO SOMETHING WORTH SERVING.


HE HAD NOT YET BEEN TESTED ON WHETHER HE WOULD STILL BELIEVE IT WHEN THE LINE FAILED HIM.
SOME ORDERS CHANGE A MAN.
OTHERS REVEAL HIM.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 3

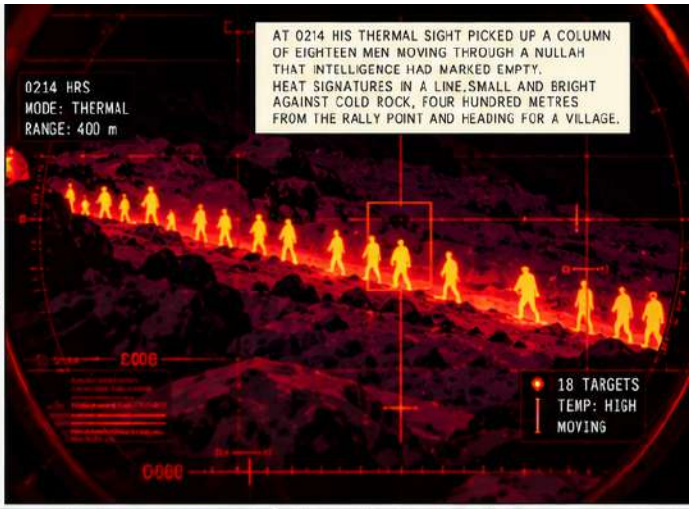
THE RIDGELINE

THE ARMY'S FILE ON THE RIDGELINE SAYS VERY LITTLE.
WHAT FOLLOWS IS WHAT ADITYA CARRIED.

HE WAS TWENTY-SEVEN, A CAPTAIN, COMMANDING A TEN-MAN TEAM ON A NIGHT RECONNAISSANCE ALONG A BORDER RIDGE AT TWELVE THOUSAND FEET. THE ORDERS WERE PLAIN. MOVE TO THE RALLY POINT. OBSERVE. REPORT. DO NOT ENGAGE.

HE HAD READ THE PLAN ELEVEN TIMES.





AT 0214 HIS THERMAL SIGHT PICKED UP A COLUMN OF EIGHTEEN MEN MOVING THROUGH A NULLAH THAT INTELLIGENCE HAD MARKED EMPTY. HEAT SIGNATURES IN A LINE. SMALL AND BRIGHT AGAINST COLD ROCK, FOUR HUNDRED METRES FROM THE RALLY POINT AND HEADING FOR A VILLAGE.

HE CALLED IT IN.
COMMAND SAID HOLD POSITION.
ADITYA WATCHED THE COLUMN THROUGH THE SIGHT, AND DID THE ARITHMETIC OF THE VILLAGE. THEY WILL REACH THE FIRST HOUSES IN TWENTY MINUTES.

This is Alpha-3. Confirm. Eighteen hostiles. Request permission to engage.

Alpha-3, hold position. Repeat. Hold position.

THEN HE MADE THE ONE DECISION HE HAD SPENT FOUR YEARS BEING TRAINED NOT TO MAKE.
HE TOOK SIX MEN OFF THE RIDGE TO INTERCEPT.

HE WAS RIGHT ABOUT THE COLUMN.
HE WAS WRONG ABOUT EVERYTHING ELSE.

THE COLUMN WAS BAIT. BEHIND IT, IN GROUND THE INTELLIGENCE HAD NOT COVERED, A SECOND GROUP WAS WAITING FOR EXACTLY THIS KIND OF MOVE. THE AMBUSH OPENED AT 0251.

NAIK GURMEET SINGH WAS KILLED IN THE FIRST BURST. SEPOY LAXMAN MEENA LIVED FOR FORTY MINUTES MORE, LONG ENOUGH FOR ADITYA TO DRAG HIM BEHIND A BOULDER AND PRESS BOTH HANDS OVER A WOUND THAT DID NOT CARE HOW HARD HE PRESSED.

Is the village safe, sir?

Yes.

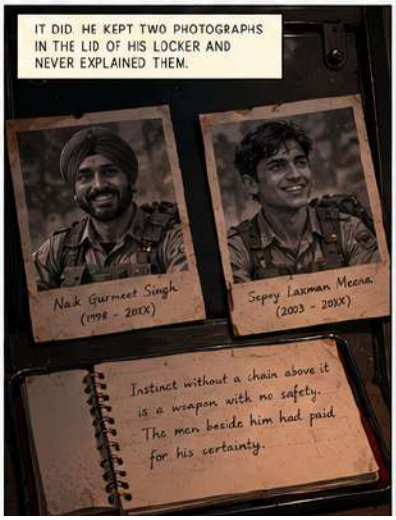
IT WAS THE FIRST THING HE HAD SAID IN FORTY MINUTES THAT HE DID NOT KNOW TO BE TRUE.

THE INQUIRY CLEARED HIM.
THE PLAN HAD GAPS, THE BOARD FOUND, AND THE INTELLIGENCE WAS INCOMPLETE, AND A YOUNG OFFICER'S JUDGMENT UNDER FIRE WAS UNDERSTANDABLE.

COLONEL NAIR SIGNED THE FINDINGS AND THEN TOLD HIM PRIVATELY:

You saw something real, Aditya. You acted on it alone. That's the part that will stay with you.

IT DID. HE KEPT TWO PHOTOGRAPHS IN THE LID OF HIS LOCKER AND NEVER EXPLAINED THEM.



HE DRAW A CONCLUSION, BECAUSE HE WAS A MAN WHO DREW CONCLUSIONS.

HE DID NOT IMPROVISE AGAIN.
HE DID NOT NEED TO.
THE CHAIN OF COMMAND WAS NOT A CAGE. IT WAS THE THING THAT HAD BEEN MISSING IN THE DARK.

YEARS LATER, WHEN HIS OWN EYES BEGAN TO SEE HEAT THE WAY THAT THERMAL SIGHT HAD, HE THOUGHT OF THAT NIGHT.

HE DID NOT TELL ANYONE.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 4

THE OFFER

AT THIRTY-ONE, ADITYA RECEIVED A COMMENDATION HE COULD NOT EXPLAIN TO ANYONE AND AN INVITATION HE COULD NOT REFUSE.

THE INVITATION CAME AS A PLAIN BROWN ENVELOPE AND A CAR TO A GUEST HOUSE IN THE JODHPUR CANTONMENT WHERE NO ONE STOOD AT THE GATE.

COMMANDER SHALINI BOSE WAS WAITING ON THE VERANDA WITH TWO GLASSES OF TEA. SHE WAS FORTY-EIGHT THEN, LEAN, WITH A QUALITY OF STILLNESS HE RECOGNISED FROM THE BEST OFFICERS HE HAD SERVED UNDER: NOT CALM EXACTLY, BUT THE ABSENCE OF ANYTHING WASTED.

Your grandfather was Havildar Madan Singh. Pokhran perimeter. The eighteenth of May, 1974.

He's been dead six years, ma'am.

He signed a paper that morning. So did every man on that line. The paper said he had seen nothing. He told you anyway, on a roof, when you were ten.

How could you possibly know that?

We read the families, Major. It's a small unit with a long memory.

THE TEA WENT COLD BETWEEN THEM WHILE SHE TOLD HIM WHAT SHE WAS PERMITTED TO TELL. A DIVISION THAT DID NOT EXIST. A SITE UNDER THE POKHRAN RANGE. A FORCE THE DIVISION CALLED AGNI-SHAKTI, DORMANT IN THE ROCK FOR LONGER THAN THERE HAD BEEN A ROCK TO BE DORMANT IN. AND A PROGRAMME, FORTY YEARS OLD AND STILL UNFINISHED, CALLED HAVAN.

PROJECT HAVAN
POKHRAN UNDERGROUND FACILITY
CLASSIFIED

"Six candidates before you," she said. "Three died. Three are alive, and will not leave the facility. I am not going to soften that."

01	02	03
DECEASED	DECEASED	DECEASED
04	05	06
ACTIVE (STILL AT FACILITY)	ACTIVE (STILL AT FACILITY)	ACTIVE (STILL AT FACILITY)

Why me?

Because you don't improvise.

I read the inquiry into the ridgeline. A man who has learned what unsupported certainty costs is exactly who should carry this.

If it were given to someone who trusted their own judgment over their orders, it would be a catastrophe. You will answer to me. That isn't a flaw in the plan. That is the plan.

And if the orders are wrong?

Then they'll be wrong in the open, with a record and a name on them. That's better than being wrong alone in the dark.

HE THOUGHT OF LAXMAN. HE THOUGHT OF THE POSTCARDS IN THE TIN.

SHE HAD USED HIS WORST NIGHT AS A REFERENCE, AND IT DID NOT CROSS HIS MIND THAT SHE HAD CHOSEN IT, ONLY THAT SHE HAD READ IT CLOSELY ENOUGH TO UNDERSTAND HIM.

HE TOOK THAT FOR RESPECT.

Leh. All well. Weather tough. Good men. Learning. Your son, Aditya.

HE TOLD HIS FATHER IT WAS A SPECIAL POSTING. BHANWAR SINGH LOOKED AT HIM FOR A LONG MOMENT, THE WAY ONE OLD SOLDIER LOOKS AT ANOTHER WHO HAS BEEN GIVEN A DOOR HE CAN'T DESCRIBE.

Then do it well.

Yes, Papa.

HIS FATHER KEPT THEM IN A TIN.

Leh. All well. Good men. Learning. Your son, Aditya.

Received 12 Oct 2023 — Bhanwar Singh Shekhawat

HE TOLD NO ONE THE NUMBER SIX.

SOME DOORS ARE NOT GIVEN TO EVERYONE.

ONLY TO THOSE WHO CAN CARRY WHAT OTHERS CANNOT.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 5

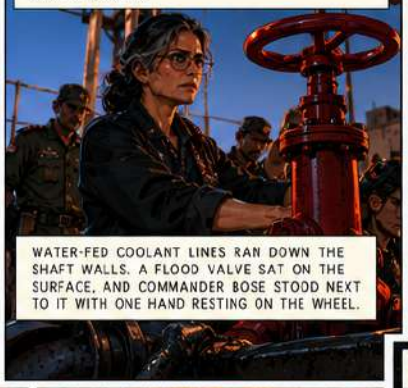
THE SHAFT

THE TEST SHAFT AT POKHRAN IS A HUNDRED AND SEVEN METRES DEEP, A CYLINDER OF CONCRETE AND RUST DRILLED THROUGH THE SAND IN 1974 AND ABANDONED AFTER, SEALED UNDER STEEL PLATES IN A STRETCH OF DESERT THAT APPEARS ON NO CIVILIAN MAP.

ON A MARCH MORNING AT FOUR O'CLOCK, THREE YEARS AGO, ADITYA SHEKHAWAT WAS LOWERED INTO IT IN A STEEL CAGE.

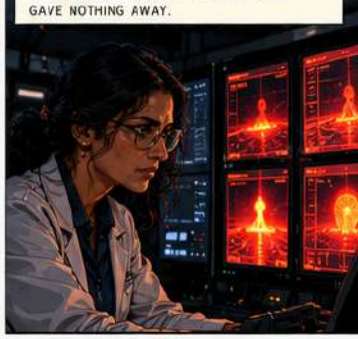


THE DIVISION HAD PREPARED THE WAY IT PREPARED FOR EVERYTHING: AS IF FAILURE WERE THE ONLY CERTAIN OUTCOME.

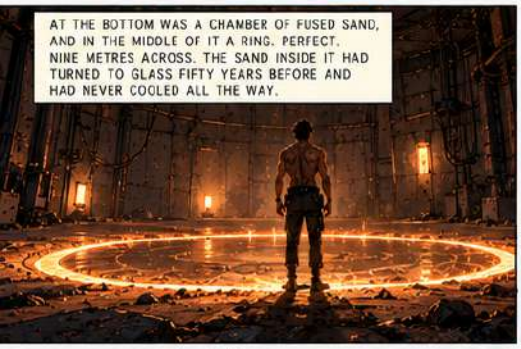


WATER-FED COOLANT LINES RAN DOWN THE SHAFT WALLS. A FLOOD VALVE SAT ON THE SURFACE, AND COMMANDER BOSE STOOD NEXT TO IT WITH ONE HAND RESTING ON THE WHEEL.

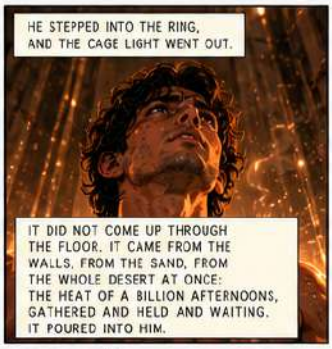
DR. AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY, THE DIVISION'S CAPABILITY ASSESSOR, WATCHED A BANK OF THERMAL MONITORS WITH A FACE THAT GAVE NOTHING AWAY.



AT THE BOTTOM WAS A CHAMBER OF FUSED SAND, AND IN THE MIDDLE OF IT A RING. PERFECT. NINE METRES ACROSS. THE SAND INSIDE IT HAD TURNED TO GLASS FIFTY YEARS BEFORE AND HAD NEVER COOLED ALL THE WAY.



HE STEPPED INTO THE RING, AND THE CAGE LIGHT WENT OUT.

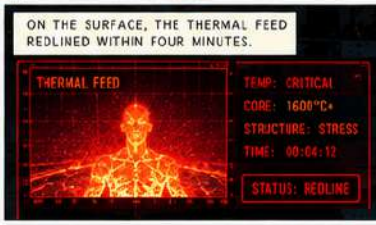


IT DID NOT COME UP THROUGH THE FLOOR. IT CAME FROM THE WALLS, FROM THE SAND, FROM THE WHOLE DESERT AT ONCE: THE HEAT OF A BILLION AFTERNOONS, GATHERED AND HELD AND WAITING. IT POURED INTO HIM.

IT WAS NOT PAIN. PAIN WOULD HAVE BEEN A MERCY, A BOUNDARY. IT WAS SIMPLY TOO MUCH OF EVERYTHING.



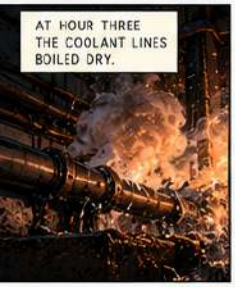
ON THE SURFACE, THE THERMAL FEED REDLINED WITHIN FOUR MINUTES.



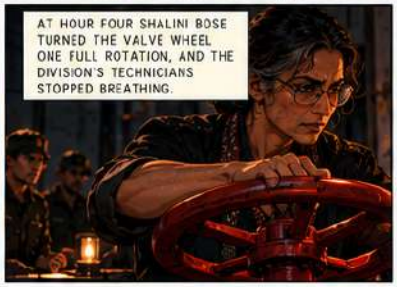
THE CONCRETE OF THE SHAFT BEGAN TO TICK AS IT EXPANDED.



AT HOUR THREE THE COOLANT LINES BOILED DRY.



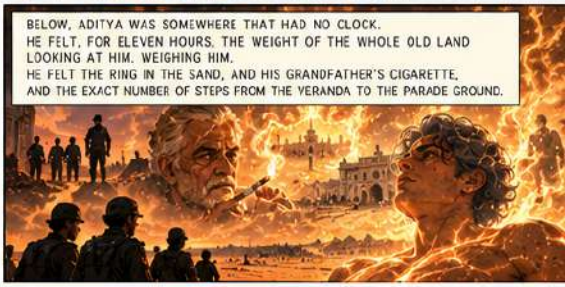
AT HOUR FOUR SHALINI BOSE TURNED THE VALVE WHEEL ONE FULL ROTATION, AND THE DIVISION'S TECHNICIANS STOPPED BREATHING.



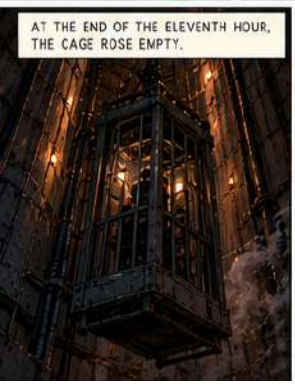
DR. AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY PUT HER HAND FLAT OVER SHALINI'S AND SAID, VERY QUIETLY:



BELOW, ADITYA WAS SOMEWHERE THAT HAD NO CLOCK. HE FELT, FOR ELEVEN HOURS, THE WEIGHT OF THE WHOLE OLD LAND LOOKING AT HIM. WEIGHING HIM. HE FELT THE RING IN THE SAND, AND HIS GRANDFATHER'S CIGARETTE, AND THE EXACT NUMBER OF STEPS FROM THE VERANDA TO THE PARADE GROUND.



AT THE END OF THE ELEVENTH HOUR, THE CAGE ROSE EMPTY.



A FIGURE CLIMBED THE MAINTENANCE LADDER, RUNG BY RUNG, A HUNDRED AND SEVEN METRES, NAKED, STEAMING, BURNING GOLD-WHITE AND NOT CONSUMED.



THE HOSE TEAM ON THE SURFACE RAISED THEIR NOZZLES. ADITYA STOPPED AT THE LIP OF THE SHAFT AND LOOKED AT THEM WITH EYES THAT HAD CHANGED COLOUR.



THEN, BECAUSE HE DID NOT KNOW HOW ELSE TO BEGIN, HE TURNED TO COMMANDER BOSE AND CAME TO ATTENTION.





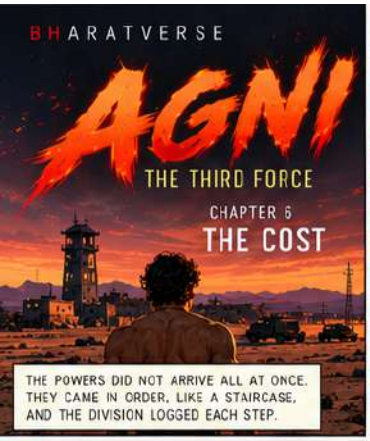
BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 6

THE COST

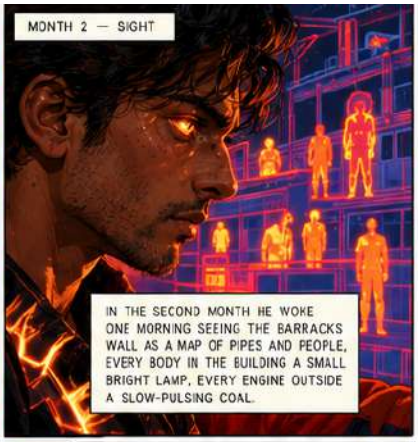


THE POWERS DID NOT ARRIVE ALL AT ONCE. THEY CAME IN ORDER, LIKE A STAIRCASE, AND THE DIVISION LOGGED EACH STEP.



MONTH 1 — FIRE

IN THE FIRST MONTH HE FOUND HE COULD NOT BE BURNED. A HOT-PLATE, A BLOWTORCH, A PIT OF DIESEL SET ALIGHT ON THE RANGE: HE WALKED THROUGH EACH AND FELT ONLY WARMTH, AS IF THEY WERE WEATHER.



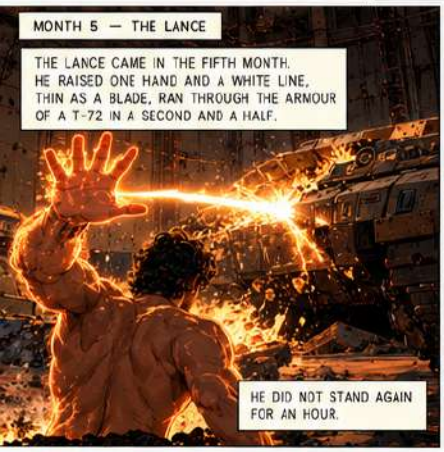
MONTH 2 — SIGHT

IN THE SECOND MONTH HE WOKE ONE MORNING SEEING THE BARRACKS WALL AS A MAP OF PIPES AND PEOPLE, EVERY BODY IN THE BUILDING A SMALL BRIGHT LAMP, EVERY ENGINE OUTSIDE A SLOW-PULSING COAL.



MONTH 3 — BULLETS

IN THE THIRD MONTH A RIFLE ROUND, FIRED AT HIS CHEST FROM TEN METRES, BECAME A BEAD OF MOLTEN LEAD IN THE AIR AND LANDED AGAINST HIS STERNUM LIKE A THROWN PEBBLE. IT STILL LEFT A BRUISE.



MONTH 5 — THE LANCE

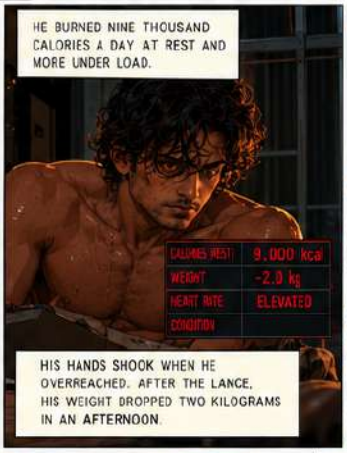
THE LANCE CAME IN THE FIFTH MONTH. HE RAISED ONE HAND AND A WHITE LINE, THIN AS A BLADE, RAN THROUGH THE ARMOUR OF A T-72 IN A SECOND AND A HALF.

HE DID NOT STAND AGAIN FOR AN HOUR.



THAT WAS WHERE AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY CAME INTO HIS LIFE. SHE SAT BESIDE HIM ON THE SAND AND PUT GLUCOSE BETWEEN HIS LIPS AS IF FEEDING AN EXHAUSTED CHILD.

You're not generating energy, Major. No one can. You're converting something. We think it's you.



HE BURNED NINE THOUSAND CALORIES A DAY AT REST AND MORE UNDER LOAD.

CALORIES (REST)	9,000 kcal
WEIGHT	-2.0 kg
HEART RATE	ELEVATED
CONDITION	

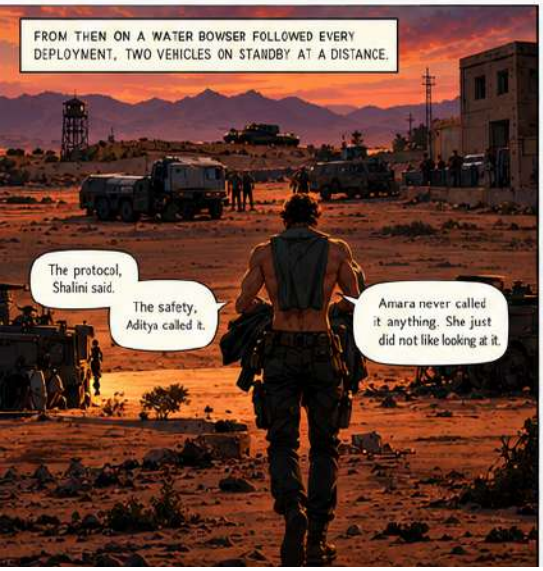
HIS HANDS SHOOK WHEN HE OVERREACHED. AFTER THE LANCE, HIS WEIGHT DROPPED TWO KILOGRAMS IN AN AFTERNOON.



THE WEAKNESS

THE DIVISION FOUND THE OTHER LIMIT BY ACCIDENT, WHEN A TECHNICIAN TURNED A HOSE ON HIM. THE WHITE WENT OUT OF HIM IN SECONDS.

HIS KNEES GAVE. HE LAY IN THE WET SAND, SHIVERING AND ORDINARY, AND DISCOVERED THAT THE THING THAT MADE HIM FEEL INVINCIBLE COULD BE UNDONE BY A GARDEN PIPE. HE WAS STRANGELY RELIEVED.



FROM THEN ON A WATER BOWSER FOLLOWED EVERY DEPLOYMENT, TWO VEHICLES ON STANDBY AT A DISTANCE.

The protocol, Shalini said.

The safety, Aditya called it.

Amara never called it anything. She just did not like looking at it.



THE DIVISION NEEDED A DESIGNATION.

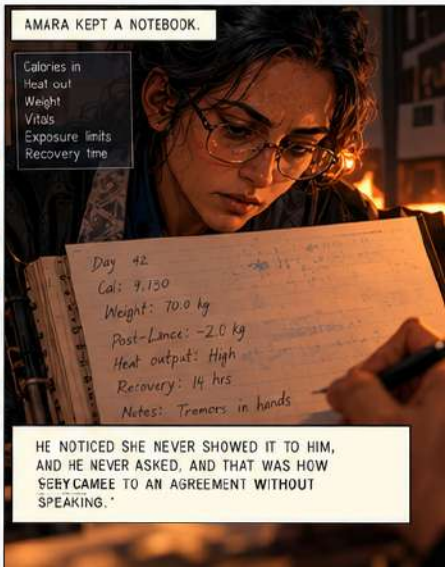
"Asset Alpha," Shalini suggested.

"Something I can say aloud, ma'am.

She considered. "Your grandfather called it a ring of fire. Agni will do."

"It's not a name, ma'am. It's a god."

"Then be careful with it."



AMARA KEPT A NOTEBOOK.

Calories in
Heat out
Weight
Vitals
Exposure limits
Recovery time

Day 42
Cal: 9,130
Weight: 70.0 kg
Post-Lance: -2.0 kg
Heat output: High
Recovery: 14 hrs
Notes: Tremors in hands

HE NOTICED SHE NEVER SHOWED IT TO HIM, AND HE NEVER ASKED, AND THAT WAS HOW THEY CAME TO AN AGREEMENT WITHOUT SPEAKING.

BHARATVERSE

AGNI

THE THIRD FORCE

CHAPTER 7

UNSEEN WORK

FOR THREE YEARS HE WORKED WITHOUT A SINGLE LINE IN A NEWSPAPER.

THIRTY-ONE DEPLOYMENTS, BY THE DIVISION'S COUNT. MOST OF THEM HE COULD NOT HAVE DESCRIBED TO HIS OWN FATHER.

A HOSTAGE HELD IN A SALT WORKS NEAR THE BORDER.

A MUNITIONS STORE IN THE THAR THAT WAS DUE TO GO UP WITH A VILLAGE BESIDE IT.

A FLASH FLOOD IN A GORGE NEAR MOUNT ABU.

HE STOOD IN FRONT OF IT FOR TWENTY MINUTES WITH THE BOWSER TEAM GASPING BEHIND HIM, BECAUSE THE ONE THING THAT COULD NOT HAPPEN WAS FOR THE DIVISION TO GET ITS OWN MAN WET.

THE NIGHT HE REMEMBERED BEST WAS AN ORDINARY ONE.

A CHEMICAL TANKER ON THE JODHPUR-PALI HIGHWAY, TIPPED ON ITS SIDE, LEAKING SOMETHING THAT WOULD IGNITE IN FOUR MINUTES AND REACH A LORRY PARK WHERE FORTY DRIVERS WERE ASLEEP.

HE ARRIVED WITH THE DAWN BEHIND HIM AND DID WHAT ONLY HE COULD DO: WALKED INTO THE FIRE AND DREW EVERY DEGREE OF IT OUT, QUIETLY, UNTIL THE TANKER WAS COLD STEEL WITH A PUDDLE OF UNLIT CHEMICAL BESIDE IT.

NOBODY SAW HIM.

I tell you, there was a man made of lamplight.. walking out of the flames!

Arre, stop it yaar. You were half asleep. It was probably the heat and smoke.

ONE TRUCKER, HALF-AWAKE IN HIS CAB, TOLD A ROADSIDE TEA-SELLER THE NEXT MORNING THAT HE HAD SEEN A MAN MADE OF LAMPLIGHT WALKING OUT OF THE FLAMES. THE TEA-SELLER LAUGHED.

HIS FATHER ASKED ONCE WHAT HE DID NOW.

What do you do now?

Logistics, Papa.

Bhanwar Singh looked at the son he had pinned stars on. He said nothing for a while.

Eat properly. You're thin.

AFTER THE TANKER, SHALINI BOSE DEBRIEFED HIM IN THE PLAIN POKHRAN OFFICE WHERE THE WALLS WERE THE COLOUR OF OLD TEETH.

Do you ever worry that you are being used, Major?

SHE ASKED THE QUESTIONS SHE ALWAYS ASKED, AND AT THE END SHE ASKED THE ONE SHE DID NOT USUALLY ASK.

Fire doesn't ask who it's burning for. Someone has to hold the match. I'd rather it be someone who answers to a flag.

SHE WROTE NOTHING DOWN. SHE SAID, "THAT'S A GOOD ANSWER," AND HE SAW SOMETHING CROSS HER FACE THAT HE COULD NOT NAME.

HE REGRETTED IT AFTERWARDS. NOT BECAUSE IT WAS FALSE. IT HAD SOUNDED, IN THE QUIET OF THAT ROOM, LIKE A SPEECH. AND TRUE THINGS SAID ALOUD IN THAT WAY SOMETIMES SOUND LIKE A MAN ARGUING WITH HIMSELF.

IN THE SUMMER OF THAT YEAR A TWELVE-SECOND CLIP OF A MAN FLYING THROUGH A MONSOON RESCUE ON A COLLAPSING BRIDGE WENT THROUGH EVERY PHONE IN THE COUNTRY.

BREAKING NEWS

Real Life Superhero Saves Dozens in Monsoon Rescue!

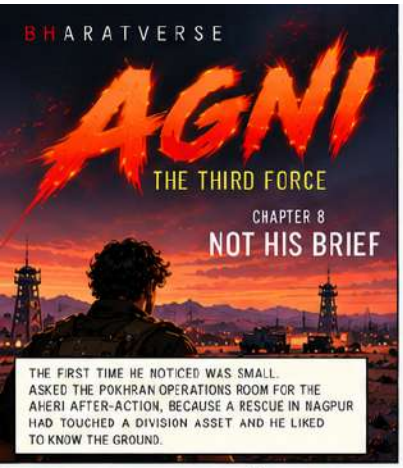
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ADITYA WATCHED IT FOUR TIMES. HE FELT RESPECT. HE FELT SOMETHING UNDER THE RESPECT THAT HE DID NOT LIKE, AND MADE HIMSELF LOOK AT.

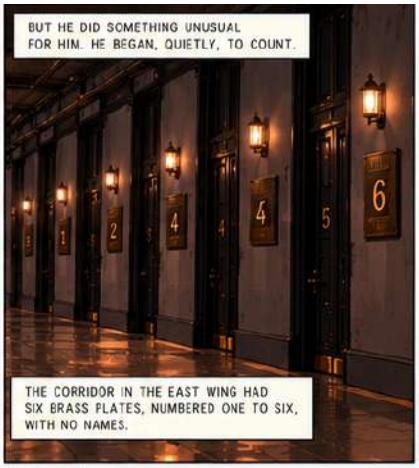
THE MAN IN THE CLIP WAS SEEN. HE WAS THANKED. STRANGERS LEFT FLOWERS FOR HIM.

ADITYA HAD SAVED MORE PEOPLE THAT YEAR AND NOBODY KNEW HIS FACE. HE TOLD HIMSELF THAT WAS THE POINT.

HE MOSTLY BELIEVED IT.


BHARATVERSE
AGNI
THE THIRD FORCE
CHAPTER 8
NOT HIS BRIEF
THE FIRST TIME HE NOTICED WAS SMALL. ASKED THE POKHRAN OPERATIONS ROOM FOR THE AHERI AFTER-ACTION, BECAUSE A RESCUE IN NAGPUR HAD TOUCHED A DIVISION ASSET AND HE LIKED TO KNOW THE GROUND.


THE DUTY OFFICER LOOKED AT THE SCREEN, THEN AT HIM, THEN AT THE DOOR, AND SAID IT WAS RESTRICTED.
By whom?
Western sector, sir.
He did not push. He was not a man who pushed.


BUT HE DID SOMETHING UNUSUAL FOR HIM. HE BEGAN, QUIETLY, TO COUNT.
THE CORRIDOR IN THE EAST WING HAD SIX BRASS PLATES, NUMBERED ONE TO SIX, WITH NO NAMES.


THE THREE SURVIVORS OF THE PROGRAMME LIVED BEHIND A DOOR AT THE END OF IT.
Is the desert still there?
WHEN HE VISITED, ONCE A MONTH, ONE OF THEM, A WOMAN WHO COULD NO LONGER BEAR COLD, ASKED HIM. HE SAID YES. SHE NODDED AS IF THAT SETTLED SOMETHING.


THE AHERI FILE WAS SEALED.
CLASSIFIED
OPERATION AHERI
AFTER ACTION REPORT
RESTRICTED ACCESS
WESTERN SECTOR


THE HIMALAYAN FLAG THAT THE WESTERN SECTOR HAD OPENED IN THE SPRING WAS SEALED.
CLASSIFIED
HIMALAYAN FLAG
OPERATION BRIEF
RESTRICTED

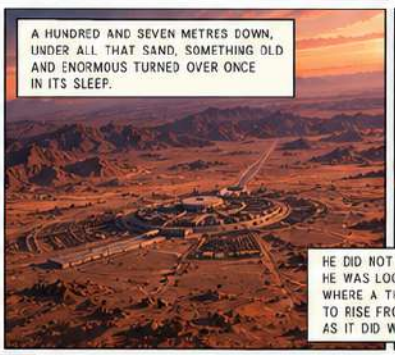

THE REASON AMARA HAD BEEN PULLED FROM THE NAGPUR WORK AND PUT BACK ON HIS FUEL LOGS: SEALED.
CLASSIFIED
PERSONNEL REALIGNMENT
Dr. AMARA KRISHNAMURTHY
Nagpur Assignment
RESTRICTED


WHEN HE ASKED, SHALINI BOSE SAID THE SAME FOUR WORDS, EVENLY, EVERY TIME.
Not your brief, Major.


HE COUNTED NINE THINGS ON THE FLIGHT TO MUMBAI. THEN HE STOPPED COUNTING, OUT OF RESPECT FOR THE INSTITUTION.

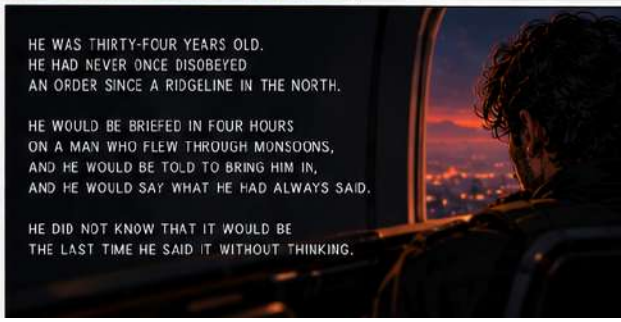

AMARA CAME TO SEE HIM OFF AT THE POKHRAN STRIP. SHE STOOD BESIDE THE DIVISION TRANSPORT WITH HER HANDS IN HER COAT POCKETS.
Eat before you land. Properly. Not the bars.
Yes, ma'am.
Aditya.
Whatever she gives you tonight, ask what's missing from the page.
I don't read the pages I'm not given.
That is exactly the trouble.
She smiled, because she thought she was being kind, and went up the ramp.


THE TRANSPORT LIFTED INTO A SKY THE COLOUR OF A STRUCK COAL, AND THE DESERT FELL AWAY BENEATH HIM.


A HUNDRED AND SEVEN METRES DOWN, UNDER ALL THAT SAND, SOMETHING OLD AND ENORMOUS TURNED OVER ONCE IN ITS SLEEP.


HE DID NOT FEEL IT. HE WAS LOOKING AT HIS HANDS, WHERE A THIN GREY SMOKE HAD BEGUN TO RISE FROM THE KNUCKLES, AS IT DID WHEN HE WAS TIRED.




HE WAS THIRTY-FOUR YEARS OLD.
HE HAD NEVER ONCE DISOBEYED AN ORDER SINCE A RIDGELINE IN THE NORTH.
HE WOULD BE BRIEFED IN FOUR HOURS ON A MAN WHO FLEW THROUGH MONSOONS, AND HE WOULD BE TOLD TO BRING HIM IN, AND HE WOULD SAY WHAT HE HAD ALWAYS SAID.
HE DID NOT KNOW THAT IT WOULD BE THE LAST TIME HE SAID IT WITHOUT THINKING.